

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 8 OF 12

Two Flames

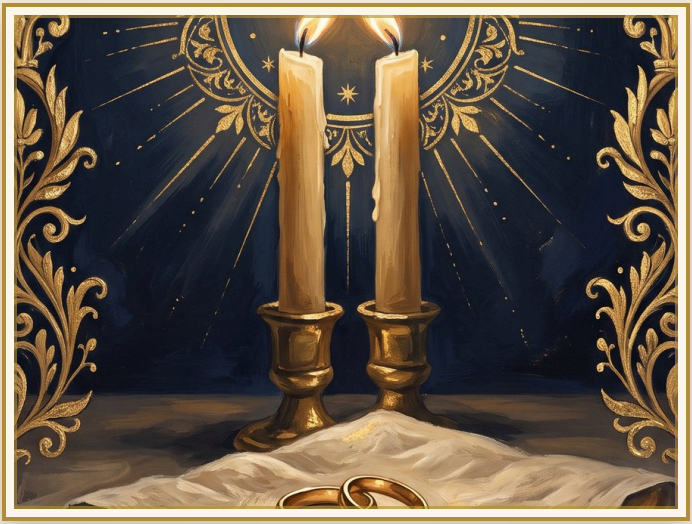
FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For two people at one table, and for the one who now sets the table for one.



Father Lucas



BOOK 8

This book: Marriage, reconciliation, and the love that goes on after the person.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

The Year of Untied Knots · Book 8 of 12 · Days 215–244

Psalm of the month: Psalm 127.

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

Good morning, my friend.

I was never married, so I won't pretend to know your table from the inside. But I have sat at a great many kitchen tables, and I've learned two things. A marriage is held up by small words and small deeds. And love does not leave when the person does. It only changes where it lives. I have buried my parents. I know how long a quiet house can feel.

This month is for the couple that has gone quiet. It is for the one who sits alone across an empty chair. And it is for anyone with a sorry still stuck in the throat. Bring all of it. Mary, Undoer of Knots, has untied harder ones.

Father Lucas

BOOK 8

THE MONTH AT A GLANCE

Week 1 · Days 1–7: The table for two. What went quiet between you, and the small words that can bring it back.

Week 2 · Days 8–14: Chairs, gratitude, an apology with no "but," and the long look at one old photograph.

Week 3 · Days 15–21: The empty chair. Talking to them still, the ring, and love that keeps going after the person.

Week 4 · Days 22–30: Old dust, the anniversary, Mary and Joseph at home, and two flames in one room.

BOOK 8

THREE PROMISES FOR THE MONTH

I. *I will say one small kind word before I say anything else.*

II. *I will say sorry once, plainly, with no "but."*

III. *I will say their name out loud, and not be ashamed.*

IV. --

MY NAME



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WEEK 1

The table for two

DAYS 215 TO 221

What went quiet between you, and the small words that can bring it back.



DAY 215

The Table for Two

Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, then I will come in to him and will dine with him, and he with me.

REVELATION 3:20 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Look at your table for a moment. Some of you have two cups on it today. Some of you have one, and a second you still can't put away.

This month begins at the table, because a marriage lives there. Not in the photograph, and not in the church. It lives where two people pass the salt and say too little, or just enough.

A knot in a marriage is a thread that stopped being pulled from both ends. Mary kept a table for two for many years. She knows how to set it again.

Lord Jesus, you once stood at a door and knocked. Here is my door, and here is my table. Here is the chair across from me, whether someone sits in it or not. Come in and sit with us, or sit with me in the quiet. Teach me to set this table again with open hands. Amen.



TODAY

Clear one square foot of your kitchen table. Set a candle or your Bible there, and sit in your usual place for one full minute.

☐ DONE

When did I last really look across this table?

PSALM

122 — "I was glad when they said, let's go to the LORD's house"; the psalm for a home with room in it.



DAY 216

Who You Married

I will betroth you to me forever. Yes, I will betroth you to me in righteousness, in justice, in loving kindness, and in compassion.

HOSEA 2:19 (WEB)

You didn't marry the person at your table today. You married someone younger, with a laugh you could pick out of a crowd. Or maybe that laugh is the thing you miss most right now.

Time wore both of you. That's no sin. But somewhere along the way you started looking at who you remember, or who you wish they were, and stopped looking at who is really there. Today, look at the real one. The one who still hums off key.

Mary saw her Son as a child and as a man at once. She can teach you that kind of seeing.

Mary, you saw your Son whole, the child and the man at once. Help me see the one I married that way today. Let me love the person in front of me, and thank God for the person I remember. Soften whatever in me has gone hard from waiting. Give me one gentle look, and one gentle word, before the day is out. Amen.



TODAY

Write one sentence that begins, “The day I knew was…” Put the paper where you’ll find it again tonight.

☐ DONE

What do I still love about them that I haven’t said?

PSALM

127 — "unless the LORD builds the house"; the psalm for a marriage that began as someone else's promise too.



DAY 217

The Small Things You Stopped Saying

Let your speech always be with grace, seasoned with salt, that you may know how you ought to answer each one.

COLOSSIANS 4:6 (WEB)

Think of the small words. "Good morning." "Thank you for the coffee." "Did you sleep?" Somewhere in the last years they fell out of the day, like coins out of a torn pocket.

Nobody decided to stop. It happened one quiet breakfast at a time. The big words were never going to hold a house up alone. A marriage stands on small words, said a thousand times and hardly noticed. If your spouse is gone, you know exactly which ones you miss.

A small word is a thread. Pick one up today and pull it gently.

Lord, my kitchen is full of small words I forgot to say. Give them back to me, one at a time. Let "thank you" come easy, and let "good morning" come warm. If the one I would say them to is gone, let them hear me anyway. Tonight I'll practice again, and tomorrow, and the day after. Amen.



TODAY

Say “thank you” out loud to your spouse for three small things today. If they are gone, say it to their photograph.

☐ DONE

Which small word do I miss hearing the most?

PSALM

141 — "set a guard, LORD, over my mouth"; the psalm for the words we say and the words we hold back. (cambiado desde 128)

DON’T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A kind word skipped for a week is harder to say on the eighth day. Say the small word again today. A thread left slack will tangle, but a hand that keeps touching it can tie it straight.



DAY 218

Cana Again

His mother said to the servants, "Whatever he says to you, do it."

JOHN 2:5 (WEB)

Every marriage has a day when the wine runs out. Not the wine in the glass. The wine of it. The joy that used to come without being asked for.

At Cana, Mary didn't announce it to the whole party. She didn't blame the groom. She noticed, quietly, and told her Son four words: "They have no wine." She didn't tell him how to fix it. She only told him the truth.

You can say those four words about your own house today. That's the whole prayer. Say what has run out, and let her carry it across the room.

Our Lady, you saw what had run out before anyone said a word. Look at my house. The laughter is thin, and the patience is thinner. I'm not asking you to fix it by supper. I'm only telling you, as you told your Son. Take it to him. I'll do whatever he tells me, even if it's small. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, in your own kitchen voice, one thing that has run out between you: patience, laughter, touch. Then add, “Mary, tell him.”

☐ DONE

What in my marriage ran out so slowly that I never noticed?

PSALM

45 — "my heart overflows with a noble theme"; the wedding psalm, for the joy that can be poured again.



DAY 219

Say It Softly

By patience a ruler is persuaded. A soft tongue breaks the bone.

PROVERBS 25:15 (WEB)

There's a way to say a hard thing, and a way that starts a war. You already know both. You've used both, in the same kitchen, on the same person.

Softness isn't weakness. A soft answer doesn't give up the point. It keeps the person. When your voice drops, theirs usually follows, and the whole room comes down with it. If your spouse is gone, the same rule holds for the voice you use on yourself.

Try it once today. Lower your voice by half, and count to three before your next word. Mary's voice never had to be loud to be heard.

Gentle Mother, my voice has a sharp edge I never meant to sharpen. Today, when the words rise up, let me take one breath first. Let me say it soft, or say nothing. Guard my tongue at the table, on the phone, and in the car, where I say my worst. Make me someone who is easy to come home to, and easy to forgive. Amen.



TODAY

Say your next hard sentence at half volume. Then wait three seconds before adding a word. Notice what the room does.

☐ DONE

Whose voice goes quiet when mine goes sharp?

PSALM

55 — "we took sweet counsel together"; the psalm for the sting of a hard word from someone close.



DAY 220

The Argument You Replay



“Be angry, and don’t sin.” Don’t let the sun go down on your wrath,

EPHESIANS 4:26 (WEB)

You've had that argument a hundred times. Again last night, in the dark, in the shower, at the stove. You win it every time, and you feel worse every time.

The argument is a knot you keep pulling tighter, hoping force will undo it. It won't. A knot answers to patience, not to winning. Some of these arguments are with someone who is still here. Some are with someone who can no longer answer. Both wear the same groove in the mind, and the groove gets deeper at night.

Today, don't win. Put the thread down for a while. Mary will hold it.

I'm tired of this argument, Lord. I know every line of it by heart, and not one line has helped. Take the whole thing out of my hands, the good points and the bad. Let me stop rehearsing and start resting. If there's a word to say, show me a gentler one, and the right hour to say it. Amen.



TODAY

Don’t replay that argument before nine tomorrow morning. Each time it starts up, whisper “Mary” and turn to the next small job.

☐ DONE

What would I say if I didn’t need to be right?

PSALM

85 — "mercy and truth meet together"; the psalm for the end of a quarrel.



DAY 221

Holding Hands in Church

I, LORD, have called you in righteousness. I will hold your hand. I will keep you, and make you a covenant for the people, as a light for the nations,

ISAIAH 42:6 (WEB)

Remember the pew. The two of you, shoulder to shoulder, and a hand finding a hand during the Our Father without either of you looking. Nobody saw. It didn't need to be seen.

That small touch said everything: I'm here, and so are you. If your hand is empty today, that's a hard line to read, and I won't pretend otherwise. But the hand still knows how to hold. It holds a rosary, a sleeve, the back of a chair.

God says, "I will hold your hand." Three hands, then: yours, your spouse's, and his. Even when one is out of sight, it's still holding.

Jesus, I come to you with my hands. Some days they are full, and some days they are empty. Take them. Hold what I'm holding, and hold what I have lost hold of. Be the third hand in my marriage, and in my memory of it. Keep your hold on me, and keep me from letting go. Amen.



TODAY

Hold a hand for one full minute without speaking. Your spouse's, if they're near. If not, hold your own, thumb moving slowly.

☐ DONE

When did we last touch without needing anything?

PSALM

101 — "I will walk within my house with a perfect heart"; the psalm for the quiet faithfulness of a home.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 222 TO 228

Chairs, gratitude, an apology with no "but," and the long look at one old photograph.



DAY 222

His Chair, Her Chair

Through wisdom a house is built; by understanding it is established; by knowledge the rooms are filled with all rare and beautiful treasure.

PROVERBS 24:3–4 (WEB)

Every couple has chairs. His has the dent. Hers has the blanket over the arm. Nobody assigned them, and nobody would dare swap. Look at yours.

A chair keeps the shape of a person after they get up. Maybe your husband's chair still faces the television and you can't bring yourself to turn it. Maybe both chairs are full and you sit miles apart. Either way, a chair is where a person rests, and where a love sits down.

Today, put something holy in one of them. A house is built slowly, chair by chair.

Bless the chairs in my house, Lord. Bless the one where I sit to be tired, and the one where my spouse sits, whether they are in it or not. Let every seat in this room be a place for peace. Come and sit with me when no one else will, and stay till I'm rested. Amen.



TODAY

Lay your rosary or a holy picture on the seat of your spouse's chair. Leave it there all day, and sit beside it once.

☐ DONE

If these chairs could talk, what would they say about us?

PSALM

122 — "peace be within your walls"; the psalm for a house that wants to be a home.



DAY 223

A Gratitude List for Your Spouse

don't cease to give thanks for you, making mention of you in my prayers,

EPHESIANS 1:16 (WEB)

Here's something a grudge never tells you: your spouse has been doing things for you for years that you stopped seeing. The car warmed up on a cold morning. The porch light left on. The soup when you were sick. The trash out before you remembered it was due.

Gratitude isn't a feeling that arrives. It's a list, and it works backward. The more you write, the more you remember. If your spouse is gone, the list is a way of keeping them in the room. If your spouse is hard to thank today, start with the smallest thing.

Don't polish it. Plain gets heard.

Father, thank you for the one who shared my years. Thank you for the unnoticed things, the small kindnesses done in the dark of the ordinary. Open my eyes to them. Where I have been blind, forgive me. Where I was thankful in silence, give me the courage to say it out loud, plainly, today. Amen.



TODAY

Write five things your spouse does, or did, for you without being asked. Read the list aloud to them, or to their photograph.

☐ DONE

What did they do for me yesterday that I never thanked them for?

PSALM

136 — "his loving kindness endures forever"; the psalm of the long thank-you. (cambiado desde 127)



DAY 224

Apology Without a But

He who conceals his sins doesn't prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them finds mercy.

PROVERBS 28:13 (WEB)

Here's a sentence most of us have said: "I'm sorry, but you..." Notice what happened. The sorry went out the door, and the but walked in and sat down.

An apology with a but is a defense wearing a bow. The other person hears the but, and only the but. A true sorry is short, and it stops. "I'm sorry I raised my voice." Period. Let the silence do its work. It may feel like standing in the cold. Stay a moment. The thaw comes.

And if the one you owe is gone, say it anyway. God carries it where you can't.

Lord, I owe an apology, and you know the name. Take away my but. Take away my need to explain. Give me three plain words and the courage to stand behind them. Let the other heart be gentle, and if it isn't, let mine stay soft anyway. Mary, walk me to the door, and wait on the porch. Amen.



TODAY

Say “I’m sorry I…” and finish the sentence with no “but” after it. Say it to your spouse, or aloud to the empty room.

☐ DONE

How would I say sorry if I knew they would forgive me?

PSALM

51 — "create in me a clean heart, God"; the psalm of a plain, whole sorry. (cambiado desde 128)

DON’T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A door left ajar doesn’t stay ajar. By evening the wind has slammed it. If you opened an apology today, finish it. A knot can be tied again, but only by hands that go back to it.



DAY 225

Silence at Dinner

Better is a dry morsel with quietness, than a house full of feasting with strife.

PROVERBS 17:1 (WEB)

Some silences at dinner are peaceful. Two people chewing, comfortable, a clock ticking somewhere. And some silences are a wall, and each of you leans on your own side of it.

I won't tell you which one is yours. You know. A silence can't be fixed by filling it with noise, and a television only hides the wall. What helps is one small sound, a plain question asked with real interest. "How was your day?" If you eat alone now, the quiet weighs differently. I know the television helps. Try one meal without it.

Today, let the room rest, and listen to it.

Tonight there's a silence at my table, Lord, and I don't know what kind it is. Let me sit in it without fear. If it's a wall, give me the first small word to climb it. If it's rest, let me enjoy it. And if it's loneliness, pull up a chair and stay with me. Amen.



TODAY

Turn off the television and the radio for one whole meal today. Ask one plain question, or simply sit and listen to the room.

☐ DONE

Is the quiet at our table a wall, or a rest?

PSALM

131 — "I have calmed and quieted my soul"; the psalm for a quiet that is not empty. (cambiado desde 45)



DAY 226

When One of You Is Ill



Even to old age I am he, and even to gray hairs I will carry you. I have made, and I will bear. Yes, I will carry, and will deliver.

ISAIAH 46:4 (WEB)

When one of you is ill, the whole marriage changes shape. The one who was strong learns to ask. The one who was asked learns to carry. Nobody practiced this. Nobody got the speech.

If you're the one who is ill, you may feel like a burden. I'd gently say you're still a husband or a wife, and that counts for more than a strong back. If you're the one who carries, you may be tired in a way sleep doesn't touch. Both are true in the same house. Neither of you is failing.

God said he would carry you to gray hair. He meant both of you.

Father, one of us is tired, and the other is tired of being strong. We didn't ask for these roles. Be the strength in the one who carries and the patience in the one who is carried. Let us be kind to each other on the hard days. Hold us both up where we can't hold each other. Amen.



TODAY

Put one hand on your own heart and one on theirs, or on the arm of their chair. Breathe in for four, out for six, three times.

☐ DONE

What do I need today that I haven't dared to ask for?

PSALM

41 — "the LORD will sustain him"; the psalm for a house where someone is weak and someone is tired. (cambiado desde 39)



DAY 227

The Wedding Photo

Above all these things, walk in love, which is the bond of perfection.

COLOSSIANS 3:14 (WEB)

Find the photograph. You know the one. Two people squinting a little at the sun, trying to look serious and failing. Their hands are bad at hiding how happy they are.

Look at their faces. They have no idea what's coming. The money, the children, the quarrels, the funerals. They said "I do" to a future they couldn't see, and they kept their word through most of it. That deserves a long look and a small bow. If one of them is gone, the other is still keeping the promise.

Whatever has frayed since that day, the vow was real. And a real thing can be mended.

Thank you, Lord, for the two young people in the photograph. They were braver than they knew. Bless the years they walked, the good and the hard. Forgive what we did to each other along the way. Take the vow we made that day and keep it in your hands, because mine are tired. Amen.



TODAY

Take the wedding photograph down, wipe the glass with your sleeve, and set it where your eyes will land first tomorrow morning.

☐ DONE

What did those two promise that I would still choose today?

PSALM

90 — "teach us to number our days"; the psalm for looking at the years honestly. (cambiado desde 55)



DAY 228

Love Is a Verb at Seventy

My little children, let's not love in word only, or with the tongue only, but in deed and truth.

1 JOHN 3:18 (WEB)

At seventy, love isn't fireworks. It's the cup set down at the right elbow. It's a slow walk matched to a slower one. It's the cold side of the bed warmed before the other one climbs in. Nobody films it. Nobody needs to.

The old apostle who wrote today's verse had watched love shrink into speeches, and he wanted it back in the hands. Yours still know where the cup goes, where the coat hangs, which jar needs opening.

Do one small thing today and tell no one. That's the whole sermon.

Lord Jesus, you washed feet. Teach my hands to do small loves today. Let me see the cup that needs filling, the coat that needs holding, the load that needs lifting. If the one I'd do it for is gone, send me someone else who needs it. Keep me from keeping score, and keep me from waiting to be thanked. Amen.



TODAY

Do one small kindness for your spouse today and say nothing about it. If they are gone, do it for someone else in their name.

☐ DONE

What small thing would they never expect from me?

PSALM

15 — "he keeps his oath even when it hurts"; the psalm for a love that stays. (cambiado desde 85)



WEEK 3

The empty chair

DAYS 229 TO 235

Talking to them still, the ring, and love that keeps going after the person.

229

DAY 229

The Empty Chair

A father of the fatherless, and a defender of the widows, is God in his holy habitation.

PSALM 68:5 (WEB)

Today is for those of you who sit across from an empty chair. I won't dress it up. A chair is a quiet thing, and it can shout. You pass it a dozen times a day, and something in you catches.

You don't have to move it. You don't have to sit in it. You don't have to explain it to the children, who think you should have changed it by now. Grief keeps its own time. The chair can stay as long as the love does.

God is a defender of widows. The book says so. Not a pity. A defender. He stands in your room, on your side.

There's an empty chair in my house, Father, and I walk around it. Today I'll stop and look at it. I miss the one who filled it. I even miss the creak. Sit with me in this room, and be my defender in the long hours. Let me feel, just once today, that I'm not alone in it. Amen.



TODAY

Sit next to the empty chair for five minutes. Say nothing, or say their name once. Then stand up and put the kettle on.

☐ DONE

What would I say if they sat in that chair for one minute?

PSALM

68 — "a defender of widows"; the psalm for a house with one person in it. (cambiado desde 134)



DAY 230

Still Talking to Him, to Her



Because he has turned his ear to me, therefore I will call on him as long as I live.

PSALM 116:2 (WEB)

You still talk to them. In the kitchen. In the car. At the sink, you answer a question nobody asked. Then you feel a little foolish, and look around, as if someone might have heard.

Listen: that isn't foolish. Love doesn't stop talking just because the other chair is quiet. The love didn't end at the funeral. It only lost its audience. And talking to someone you love is the oldest prayer there is. God doesn't mind. I suspect he leans in.

He has turned his ear to you, the psalm says. Start with the small news from the mailbox.

You know I still talk to them, Lord. You know what I say. Carry my words where I can't, and bring me back a little peace. Let me speak without shame, and let me stop when it's time to stop. Keep me from living only in the past. Keep me, too, from leaving it too quickly. Amen.



TODAY

Tell your spouse one thing about your day, out loud, the way you used to over coffee. Say it to their photograph.

☐ DONE

What have I been saving up to tell them?

PSALM

63 — "my soul thirsts for you"; the psalm of a heart that still reaches out. (cambiado desde 137)



DAY 231

The Ring

He has remembered his covenant forever, the word which he commanded to a thousand generations,

PSALM 105:8 (WEB)

It's a small circle of metal, worn thin on the inside, and it knows your marriage better than anyone. It was there when you laughed. It was there through the cold silences. It has come off for the dishes and gone back on a thousand times.

Some of you still wear it. Some keep it in a dish, or on a chain, or in a drawer you can't open. All of that's love, in different shapes. A ring has no beginning and no end, the old people said. The promise didn't run out, even where the person did.

Today, hold it and let it say what it knows.

Bless this small circle, Lord. Bless the hand that wore it and the hand that wears it now. It has been through soap and sorrow and work and years. Make it a sign today of a promise you kept even when I didn't. Hold what is tied. Mend what has worn thin. Keep us both in your hands, wherever we are. Amen.



TODAY

Hold your ring, or theirs, in your open palm. Make the Sign of the Cross over it, slowly, and say the name of the one you promised.

☐ DONE

What did I promise that day, and what still stands?

PSALM

128 — "your house like a fruitful vine"; the psalm for a home that grew from a promise. (cambiado desde 101)

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that wore the thread thin is still out there. Hold the ring again tomorrow, and the day after. A promise stays tied in the hands that keep blessing it.



DAY 232

Your Children's Marriages



All your children will be taught by the LORD, and your children's peace will be great.

ISAIAH 54:13 (WEB)

Your children chose people. Some you loved at once. Some you've been polite to for twenty years. Some are gone now, or left, and you still don't know what to call them at the table.

A marriage is never only two people. It's a whole table of in-laws, and grandchildren, and old hurts. The best thing you can do for your child's marriage isn't advice. It's prayer, quietly, with the name of the one they chose beside their own. That blessing travels farther than any phone call.

Pray for the one you didn't pick. Mary prayed for the whole wedding, including guests she'd never met.

Father, I bring you my children's marriages. I bring the ones I understand and the ones I don't. Bless the husbands and wives I didn't choose. Keep their homes peaceful. Keep my mouth gentle when I'd like to give advice. Let me be a quiet strength at the edge of their tables, and never a weight. Amen.



TODAY

Add to your Names Page the name of each child's spouse, including the one you've struggled to like.

☐ DONE

Which in-law do I most need to start praying for?

PSALM

112 — "his offspring will be mighty"; the psalm for the generations after you. (cambiado desde 17)



DAY 233

Forgive an Old Betrayal

Don't judge, and you won't be judged. Don't condemn, and you won't be condemned. Set free, and you will be set free.

LUKE 6:37 (WEB)

There's one in every long life. The thing that was said, or done, or hidden, years ago. You forgave it outside and filed it inside. And once in a while it comes out of the drawer, shining, as if it happened this morning.

Forgiving isn't forgetting, and it isn't walking back into harm. It's putting the sword down, handle first, into the hands of the One who can carry it. It may take many tries. You aren't slow. God knows the weight.

If this one is too heavy to carry alone, write to Sister Camille. She has read letters like it before.

Lord, you know the old wound by name. I have carried it so long it feels like part of me. I'm not ready to feel nothing. But I'm ready to open my fingers a little. Take what I can give today, and keep the rest safe until I can give it. Be patient with my slow heart. Amen.



TODAY

Find a small object that stands for the old hurt: a card, a key, a button. Put it in a box and close the lid.

☐ DONE

Who would I be if I put this down?

PSALM

103 — "as far as the east is from the west"; the psalm for what God has already put down.



DAY 234

Mary and Joseph's Quiet Home

And he went down with them and came to Nazareth. He was subject to them, and his mother kept all these sayings in her heart.

LUKE 2:51 (WEB)

Picture the house at Nazareth. Not the paintings, with the glow and the lilies. A real house: a low ceiling, one table, a woman at the hearth, a man at the door with tired hands.

Theirs was no easy life. A child nobody expected. A flight in the night. Years of hard work. And the book keeps one line about the home: his mother kept all these things in her heart. A house like that doesn't need much money. It needs people who keep the good in the heart, and the hard in God's hands.

Your house can be that quiet. Start with one corner.

Holy Mother, Saint Joseph, look into my house. It isn't grand. It has its own noise and its own silences. Make it a little Nazareth: plain, patient, and sure of who lives here. Bless the walls and the doors and the table. Teach us to keep the good in our hearts, and to say it out loud. Amen.



TODAY

Write “Make it a little Nazareth” on a sticky note and put it on the bathroom mirror. Read it tonight, and again in the morning.

☐ DONE

What one thing would make my house feel more like Nazareth?

PSALM

84 — "even the sparrow has found a home"; the psalm for a plain house with God in it. (cambiado desde 122)



DAY 235

A Date at the Kitchen Table



Better is a dinner of herbs, where love is, than a fattened calf with hatred.

PROVERBS 15:17 (WEB)

When did you last sit at your own kitchen table as if it were a restaurant? Napkins folded. A candle in a saucer. Nothing on the screen. Nothing to fix.

Courting didn't end because you got old. It ended because you got busy, then tired, then used to it. A date at the table costs nothing. Two cups of decaf and one clear half hour can say what the old words used to say. And if you eat alone now, be company worth lighting a candle for. You are.

Better a dinner of herbs where love is. Herbs are fine. Love is the thing.

Father, bless this table and whoever sits at it, in body or in memory. Bless the plain food, and bless the half hour I'm about to give it. If we sit here together, let us really see each other. If I sit alone, let me feel your company on the other side of the candle. Amen.



TODAY

Set the table properly once today, with a candle and cloth napkins. Eat slowly, with no screen, and look up often.

☐ DONE

What would make this half hour feel like a gift?

PSALM

127 — "unless the LORD builds the house"; the psalm for a home that is built one meal at a time.



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 236 TO 244

Old dust, the anniversary, Mary and Joseph at home, and two flames in one room.

236

DAY 236

Dust of Old Anger

He who covers an offense promotes love; but he who repeats a matter separates best friends.

PROVERBS 17:9 (WEB)

Old anger is like dust. You don't see it arrive. One morning the sun comes in low, and you see it on everything.

It's on the way you hear them chew. It's on the tone of their "I'll do it later." It isn't about the chewing, you know. It's twenty years of small things never said, settled on the furniture of the day. If your spouse has died, the dust may be anger at them, or at God, and that's hard to admit. Say it plainly. God has heard worse and stayed in the room.

You can't clear it all today. Pick up one cloth.

I didn't mean to let it settle, Lord. There's dust on my heart, years of it. I'm angry at someone I love, or loved, and perhaps a little at you. Here is the cloth. Wipe the corner I can reach today, and give me strength to do a little more tomorrow. Let love shine where the dust was. Amen.



TODAY

Wipe one dusty shelf or windowsill, slowly. While you wipe, name one small habit of theirs that irritates you, and set it down.

☐ DONE

Which small habit of theirs carries my oldest anger?

PSALM

86 — "you, Lord, are good, and ready to forgive"; the psalm for dust that has settled on a heart. (cambiado desde 109)



DAY 237

Pray Together, Even Badly

All these with one accord continued steadfastly in prayer and supplication, along with the women and Mary the mother of Jesus, and with his brothers.

ACTS 1:14 (WEB)

Couples do almost everything together except the one thing that matters most. They pray in the same pew and never in the same room. Praying aloud together can feel more private than anything else you do, and twice as shy.

You'll stumble. One of you'll start a beat early. Someone's voice will crack. That's fine. The first disciples prayed with one accord, and Mary sat among them. Not in the polished version. In the clumsy one, between two rough voices. If your spouse is gone, say both parts. I believe they hear you.

Begin with the Our Father. You both know it by heart.

Lord Jesus, you stood among those who prayed in that upper room. Stand here. Our voices are rough and our words are old. Let the Our Father be enough. Where we have prayed apart for years, bring us into the same room. Where one of us is gone, let the prayer find them anyway. Stay with us till the last word. Amen.



TODAY

Say the Our Father out loud with your spouse. If you're alone, say it slowly, and leave a space where their voice used to be.

☐ DONE

What have we never once prayed about together?

PSALM

133 — "how good and pleasant it is to dwell in unity"; the psalm of two voices in one room. (cambiado desde 128)



DAY 238

Say the Name Aloud

I will give you the treasures of darkness and hidden riches of secret places, that you may know that it is I, LORD, who calls you by your name, even the God of Israel.

ISAIAH 45:3 (WEB)

When did you last hear their name said aloud in your house? Not “he” or “she” or “your father.” The name. Their full name, the one on the wedding invitation.

After a death, people stop saying it. They are afraid it will hurt you. It does hurt. But a name unsaid hurts worse, like a room where the lamp is never lit. Saying it aloud isn’t morbid. It’s the opposite. It says: they were here, and they were someone.

God called you by your name before you could answer to it. He knows how a name sounds in the dark.

Lord, there's a name I haven't said in days. I'll say it now, in my own kitchen voice, the way I used to call it across the house. Hear it. Know the person it belongs to, as you always have. Let it be a blessing in my mouth and not only a wound. Keep them in your mercy. Amen.



TODAY

Say the full name of the one you miss, out loud, three times, slowly. Then tell the room one good short story about them.

☐ DONE

What did their name sound like when they were happy?

PSALM

139 — "you have searched me and known me"; the psalm of being known by name.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Mary never tires of your voice, but you can forget she is listening. Say the name again tomorrow. A name spoken once a day keeps a love in the room.



DAY 239

What They Taught You

Iron sharpens iron; so a man sharpens his friend's countenance.

PROVERBS 27:17 (WEB)

Nobody comes to a marriage finished. You were rough in places. So was your spouse. Over the years you filed each other down like iron on iron, and some of the sparks weren't pretty.

Look at what you can do now that you couldn't then. Cook something properly. Fix something. Wait. Say sorry. Sit quietly with a sad person. Some of that you learned from them. Some you learned in spite of them. It all counts. A marriage is a long school, and the teacher doesn't always know she's teaching.

If they're gone, the lessons aren't. They've moved into your hands.

My spouse taught me more than they knew, Lord, on purpose and by accident. Thank you for the patience I learned the hard way. Thank you for what I know how to do only because they did it first. Let me carry it forward gently. Where they hurt me while teaching, heal that, too. Let gratitude be the last word between us. Amen.



TODAY

Write a two-line note naming one thing your spouse taught you. Leave it where they'll find it, or tuck it in your Bible.

☐ DONE

What do I do every day that I learned from them?

PSALM

71 — "God, you have taught me from my youth"; the psalm of a long school. (cambiado desde 45)



DAY 240

Blessing for a Second Chance

Turn us to yourself, LORD, and we will be turned. Renew our days as of old.

LAMENTATIONS 5:21 (WEB)

Some of you aren't widowed. Some of you're separated, or half separated, living in the same house in different rooms. Some of you're one phone call from a marriage you thought was over. I'm talking to you today.

A second chance rarely arrives with music. It arrives as a small, risky thing: a text, a knock, a coffee offered. It asks for courage and gives no guarantee. I can't promise what the other heart will do. But I've seen people find the phone ringing, and I've seen a door they'd stopped watching open.

A blessing costs nothing. It can be said even to a closed door.

Lord, there's someone I haven't blessed in a long time. I bless them now. I bless their morning and their sleep. I bless whatever is hard in their life. If a second chance is coming, make me ready for it. If it isn't, let the blessing do its quiet work in me. Mary, hold the door. Amen.



TODAY

Say a blessing aloud over the person you've been estranged from, near or far. Use their name, and wish them one good thing.

☐ DONE

What would I be willing to risk for a second chance?

PSALM

126 — "restore our fortunes, the LORD"; the psalm for years that may yet be given back. (cambiado desde 60)

241

DAY 241

Loneliness Inside a Marriage

I watch, and have become like a sparrow that is alone on the housetop.

PSALM 102:7 (WEB)

There's a loneliness that has a name on the mailbox. It sits in the next chair. It sleeps six inches away. You can be lonelier in a marriage than you ever were alone, because alone, at least, nobody was expected.

I won't call it small. It's one of the hardest, and people carry it quietly, ashamed to say it, because it sounds ungrateful. It isn't. It's a hunger, and hunger isn't a sin. Begin by telling God, who can bear the truth without taking offense. Then, when you have a little courage, make one small request of the person beside you.

For now, only breathe.

Father, I'm lonely in the house I share. I don't know how to say it to the one who sits beside me. So I say it to you. Come into the space between us. Let a small door open, from either side. And until it does, be the company I'm missing. Hold my hand in the dark. Amen.



TODAY

Breathe out the word “Mary” ten times, slowly, in your favorite chair. Then ask one real question of the person nearest you.

☐ DONE

What would I ask for if I knew I wouldn’t be refused?

PSALM

25 — "I am lonely and afflicted"; the psalm for a loneliness with no name on the card. (cambiado desde 55)



DAY 242

The Anniversary

The LORD remembers us. He will bless us. He will bless the house of Israel. He will bless the house of Aaron.

PSALM 115:12 (WEB)

Today is for the anniversary, whether it falls today or not. Whether you'll go to dinner, or sit alone with a card you can't send, or hardly speak to each other. It's the day the knot was first tied, in front of witnesses, with everyone crying.

Patricia and Dale, in Dayton, lit a candle at the sink on theirs and said, "Still here." Nothing more. After he died she lit it alone and said it twice. She told me it was the best prayer she knew.

Light yours. A flame doesn't need a guest list.

Thank you for the day we said yes, Lord. Thank you for every year since, the ones I'd keep and the ones I'd gladly skip. The good was real, and so was the hard. If we're together, renew what we promised. If we're apart, let love find some way to reach across. Be the witness you were that first day. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle and say the day you were married aloud. Then say, “Still here,” and mean whatever it means in your house today.

☐ DONE

What do I most thank God for in all these years together, even now?

PSALM

92 — "it is good to give thanks"; the psalm for old trees that still bear fruit. (cambiado desde 85)

243

DAY 243

Joseph's Silence

He arose and took the young child and his mother by night and departed into Egypt,

MATTHEW 2:14 (WEB)

Joseph says nothing in the whole Gospel. Not one word of his is recorded. He doesn't argue, or explain, or defend himself. He wakes up, does what he's told, and takes his family out into the night.

We think of silence as weakness, or as the cold kind that ends marriages. Joseph's silence is the other kind. It's the silence of a man who listens first and holds a hard thing before he speaks. Many a quarrel would have died young if one of the two had been a little like Joseph for a minute.

Try his kind of quiet today. Only two minutes. See what rises.

Saint Joseph, quiet man, teach me your kind of silence. Let me listen before I answer. Let me hold the hard thing a moment before I hand it back. Make my home a place where a husband or a wife can simply be. And when I must speak, let it be the word that heals. Amen.



TODAY

Sit with your coffee and say nothing for two full minutes. Let whatever rises, rise. Then say one kind sentence.

☐ DONE

When did silence last bring us closer instead of apart?

PSALM

62 — "my soul waits in silence for God alone"; the psalm for Joseph's kind of quiet. (cambiado desde 101)



DAY 244

The Two-Flame Candle

For you will light my lamp, the LORD. My God will light up my darkness.

PSALM 18:28 (WEB)

Two flames, side by side. Notice something: neither is smaller because the other is lit. They don't compete. They don't take turns. The room is simply brighter with both.

That's the whole month in two small lights. A marriage isn't one person disappearing into another. It's two lights that learn to burn near each other without burning each other. And where one has gone out, it may be lit again, from the other, by love, by memory, by prayer. A knot that was untied can be tied again. A flame that went out can be lit again.

Light them both tonight.

Here are two flames, Lord. One is mine, small and a little unsteady. One is the love I carry, for the one who sits across from me, or the one who is gone. Keep them both alive. Let them burn near each other and warm the room. Teach me to love without losing myself, and without letting go. Amen.



TODAY

Light two candles side by side. Count ten slow breaths while you watch them, then say the names of both, yours first.

☐ DONE

Who is the second flame I'm carrying tonight?

PSALM

27 — "the LORD is my light and my salvation"; the psalm for two small lights in one room. (cambiado desde 122)

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let a flame go out once, and told myself I'd relight it in a day. A day became a year. Strike the match tonight, my friend. It's easier than starting over.

CLOSING OF BOOK 8 · TWO AT ONE TABLE

LOOKING BACK

☐ Which small word did I say this month that I had not said in a long time?

☐ Whom did I forgive, or begin to forgive, even by one finger?

☐ What did I learn to say to the empty chair, or to the full one?

☐ Which name do I want to add to my Names Page and carry with me?

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

You have sat at this table for thirty mornings. Some days it was warm. Some days it was only a table. Both count.

A knot in a marriage is a thread that stopped being pulled from both ends. This month you picked up one end. That's all anyone can do. The other end belongs to God, and to the person, and to time.

If you're still two at the table, keep the small words going. If you sit alone, keep saying the name. Neither is foolish. Love doesn't go quiet because the room has changed. A knot that was untied can be tied again, and so can a promise, and so can a peace.

— Father Lucas

THE SEAL OF THE MONTH

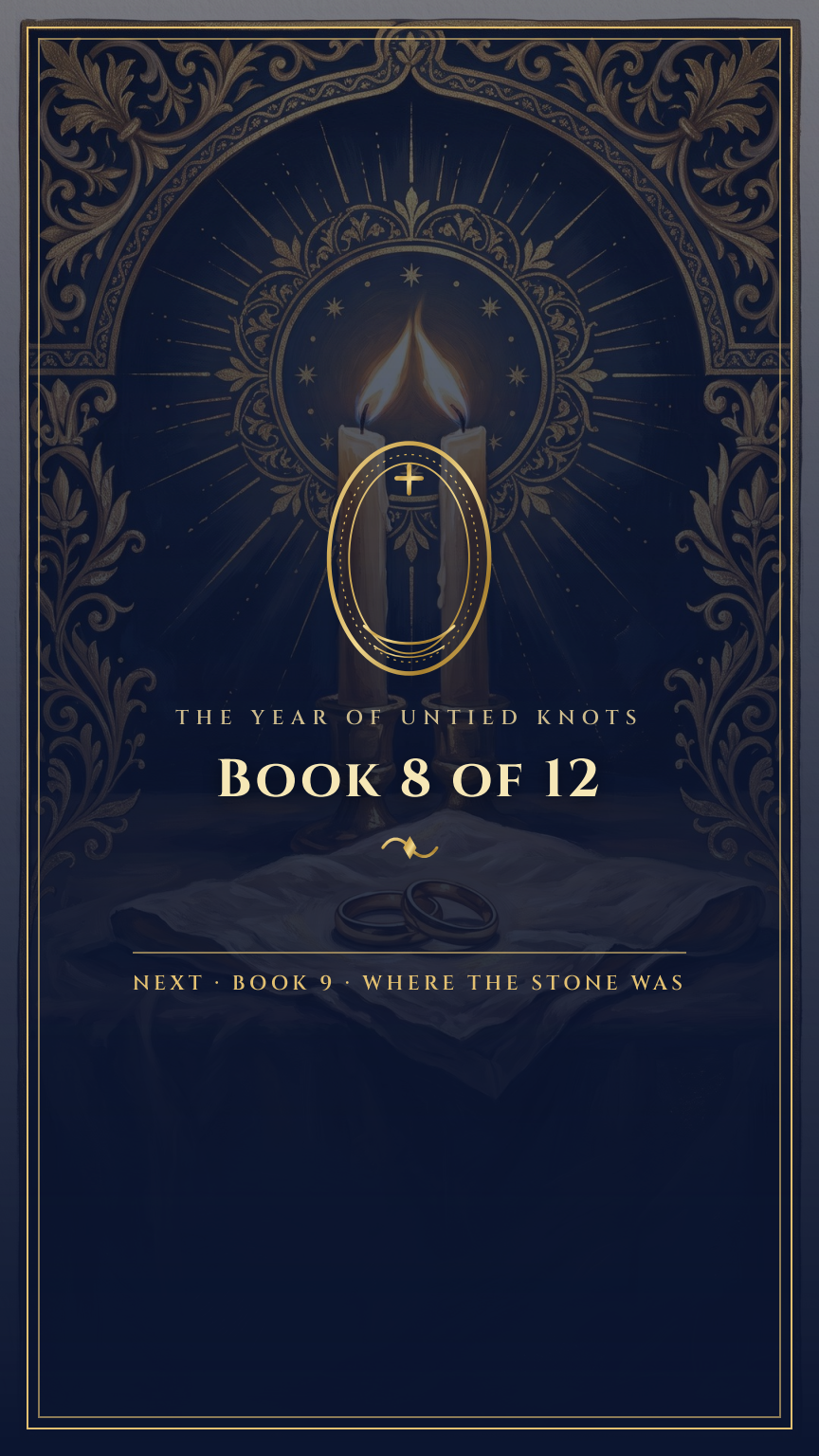
BOOK 8 · TWO AT ONE TABLE

— a gold seal with two small flames.

Date:

THE CANDLE OF THE MONTH: TWO FLAMES

Light one candle for yourself and one for the person you carry, near or gone. Say aloud the names on your Names Page. Blow both out together, and say "Amen."



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 8 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 9 · WHERE THE STONE WAS